ground, his complete indifference towards the defence of Tawang was not only shocking, it bordered on callousness. The orders for the garrison to withdraw, the resultant abandonment of tons of stores, equipment and 25-pounder guns should have resulted in the immediate sacking of the army commander. Instead, Bogey Sen got Niranjan Prasad removed for cowardice in the Nam Ka Chu battle.

All organizations, regardless of which country they belong to, have a system of checks and balances. Bijji Kaul may have, by virtue of being Nehru's man, been given the status of the Alpha male, but theoretically he still had two people above him in the chain of command. Both Thapar and Sen had been quick to adopt a submissive posture, realizing that to survive in the existing set-up, they had to take a step back. Thapar, while still the Western Army Commander, had realized that Thorat, by virtue of being cast in the Thimayya mould, was in all probability going to be sidelined once Timmy retired. Thapar's moment of truth came when his subordinate corps commander, Lieutenant General S. D. Verma, took a stand on the situation in Ladakh. As the army commander, Thapar could either back Verma and the men he commanded, thereby ruining his own chances for the top job, or keep silent. The moment Thapar took the second option, he had sold his soul to the Nehru-Menon-Kaul triumvirate and the rest of India paid the price.

Bogey Sen's case was even more intriguing. For many, he was the operational face of the Indian Army in Kashmir in 1947-48. As the commander of 161 Brigade, whose forward elements were airlifted into Srinagar even as the tribal lashkars were just a few miles from the Srinagar airfield, Sen was looked at as a highly capable and competent officer. In many ways, after Nehru and Menon had ridden roughshod over Thimayya and appointed Kaul the QMG in 1959, it was up to Bogey Sen, as the CGS, to draw the line in the sand. Sen was nobody's fool—his book on the J&K Ops, *Slender was the Thread*, showed him to possess a sharp analytical mind. By throwing his hat into Kaul's camp, Sen sounded the death knell of the army as a professional fighting arm.

When Thimayya and Thorat retired, Sen moved from being the CGS to command the Eastern Army. If there was any doubt as to where Sen's loyalty lay, it was dispelled when, in an amazing breach of protocol, Bogey Sen flew to Tezpur to receive Kaul, the newly appointed 4 Corps Commander who was to serve under him.